

Lei Gao, Ph.D.

CURRICULUM VITAE

ADDRESS

Finance Area
Costello College of Business
George Mason University, Fairfax, VA 22030
Google Scholar Citation: 2,200+ (446 in 2025)

Phone (C): 517-303-3672
Email: lgao9@gmu.edu
Citizenship: U.S. Citizen
SSRN Downloads: 19,500+

RESEARCH LEADERSHIP & IMPACT SUMMARY

- Publications in leading journals including PNAS, Journal of Financial Economics, Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis, and Research Policy.
- Research adopted by federal agencies (CDC) and informed policy discussions at HUD and the U.S. Congress.
- Extensive engagement with federal funding agencies, including NSF, DOJ, DOS; reviewer for NSF CAREER Awards.
- Active interdisciplinary collaborations across CEC, Carter School for Peace and Conflict Resolution, and CHSS.
- Sustained research visibility: 2,200+ citations; 446 citations in 2025; 19,550+ SSRN downloads.

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENT

- **Associate Professor of Finance** 2021–Present
School of Business, George Mason University, Fairfax, VA
- **Financial Economist** 2019– 2020
DERA, U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC), Washington DC
- **Assistant Professor of Finance** 2014–2021
Ivy College of Business, Iowa State University, Ames, IA
- **Assistant Professor of Finance** 2012– 2014
Fogelman College of Business and Economics, University of Memphis, Memphis, TN

EDUCATION

- **Ph.D. in Finance**, University of Georgia 2012
- **M.S. in Industrial Math**, Michigan State University 2006
- **B.S. in Computer Science**, Peking University 2000

RESEARCH INTERESTS

- Corporate Governance
- Corporate Finance
- Corporate Social Responsibility
- Machine Learning/AI/FinTech
- Investments
- Financial Econometrics

GRANTS & RESEARCH FUNDING (Selected)

- Principal Investigator, U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission IPA Grant
- Principal Investigator, Census Bureau Research Center Grants CPRDC (2)
- Multiple submissions to NSF, DOJ, DOS, and other federal funding programs
- Reviewer, NSF CAREER Awards

HONORS AND AWARDS

- Summer Research Fellow, George Mason University 2024-2025
- CCB Research Award (2), George Mason University 2025
- Best Paper in Financial Education, Academy of Finance 2025
- Research Seeding Grant, George Mason University 2023-2024
- CCB Research Award, George Mason University 2024
- OSCAR Mentor Award, George Mason University, 2024
- Academy of Finance Best Paper Award 2023
- AFA-ANZ Best Paper Award 2022
- Research Seeding Grant, George Mason University, \$10,000 2022-2023
- Research Acceleration Grant, Iowa State University 2021-2023
- Summer Research Grant, Iowa State University, \$17,500 2019
- Outstanding Paper Award, Eastern Finance Association(EFA) 2016
- Best Paper Award Finalist Financial Management Association Asia Pacific 2019, 2018
- Best Paper Award Semi Finalist Financial Management Association 2017
- PI: Research Bootstrap Grant, Iowa State University 2020, 2018, 2017, 2016, 2015, 2014
- International Research Travel Grant, Iowa State University 2018, 2015
- Principal Financial Faculty Professional Development Grant, Iowa State University 2014
- Summer Research Fund, University of Memphis 2013

- Woodruff Award, University of Georgia 2009
- Comer Award, University of Georgia 2009, 2007
- Summer Research Award, University of Georgia 2008
- Industrial Mathematics Fellowship, Michigan State University 2005
- Canon Scholarship, Peking University 1999
- Motorola Scholarship, Peking University 1997
- Second Prize in National Physics Olympiad 1994

POLICY & PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT (Selected)

- Research adopted by CDC for COVID-19 mortality forecasting
- Expert witness testimony before the U.S. Congress (Fair Lending)
- Invited speaker, Department of Housing and Urban Development
- Media coverage: Bloomberg, Washington Post, Harvard Business Review, CNN

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

1. The Economic Impact of Discriminatory Policies: Insights from Same-Sex Marriage Bans, with Liu, S., and Wang, Y. (2025, May). *AEA Papers and Proceedings* (Vol. 115, pp. 509-514) .
2. Derivatives Trading Simulation Supported by AI, with S. Gopalakrishnan, M. Ehrlich, and C. Wang. *Journal of Financial Education* (forthcoming, AoM Best paper Award in Financial Education)
3. Common Ownership Along the Supply Chain and Management Disclosure, with Han, J., Kim, JB, and Pan, T., (2024), *Journal of Corporate Finance*;
4. Local Religiosity and Financial Advisor Misconduct, with Cowan, A., Han, J., and Pan, T., (2024), *Journal of Corporate Finance*;
5. Is there a tradeoff between management earnings forecasts and sustainability reporting?, with L. Tuo and Rezaee, Z., (2024), *Global Finance Journal*
6. Challenges of COVID-19 Case Forecasting in the US, 2020–2021, with Lopez, V. K., Cramer, E. Y., Pagano, R., Drake, J. M., O’Dea, E. B., Adey, M., et al., (2024), *PLoS computational biology*
7. CEO Political orientation and the information disclosure, with Elnahas, A., Hossain, N. and Kim, JB. (2024), *Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis*, (FMA 2020, AFA 2022)

8. Individualistic CEO and Corporate Innovation: Evidence from US Frontier Culture., with Han, J., Pan, Z. and Zhang, H. (2023). *Research Policy*. (FT50, AJG 4*), Profiled in *Harvard Business Review*
9. Standing out from the crowd via CSR engagement: Evidence from non-fundamental-driven price pressure, with He, J., and Wu, J. (2023). *Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis*. Media Coverage: *Harvard Law School Forum*.
10. Count On Your Subordinates: Executives' Horizons And Innovation Efficiency, with Jiang, C., and Mekhaimer, M. (2023). *Journal of Banking and Finance*.
11. Economic Policy Uncertainty, Bank Deposits, and Liability Structure, with Deng, W., F. Xing, and M. Yang, (2023), *Emerging Markets Review*
12. Mutual Fund Dual Holdings, Shareholder-Creditor Conflicts, and Corporate Innovation, with Wang, Y. and Zhao, J. (2023), *Journal of Risk and Financial Management*
13. Evaluation of individual and ensemble probabilistic forecasts of COVID-19 mortality in the US, with Cramer et al., *PNAS*, 119(15) (2022): p.e2113561119. (Research adopted by CDC for COVID-19 mortality forecasting)
14. Spatiotemporal Autoregressive Partially Linear Varying Coefficient Models, with S. Yu, Y. Wang, L. Wang, *Statistica Sinica* (2022), 32, 2119-2146.
15. Modeling and forecasting COVID-19, with Wang, L. et al., *Notices of the American Mathematical Society*, 68(4), (2021): 585-595.
16. Comparing and integrating US COVID-19 data from multiple sources with anomaly detection and repairing.. with Wang, L. et al. *Journal of Applied Statistics*, (2021): 1-27.
17. Short-sale Constraints and Stock Price Crash Risk: Causal Evidence from a Natural Experiment, with Deng, X. and Kim, J-B., *Journal of Corporate Finance*, 60 (2020): 101498. (SSRN Top 10 download list; Featured by *Cato* Institute, Media Coverage: Oxford Business Law Blog(OBLB)).
18. Peer firms' earnings predictability and pricing efficiency—evidence from IPOs., with Rezaee, Z. and Yu, J., *European Journal of Finance*, 26(13), (2020): 1332-1353.
19. Dual-Class Firms and Innovation after NAFTA, with Zagorchev, A. *Review of Pacific Basin Financial Markets and Policies*. (2020)
20. Efficient Estimation of Partially Linear Models for Spatial Data over Complex Domains. with Wang, L., Wang, G., and Lai, M., *Statistica Sinica*, 30 (2020): 347-369.
21. Lending practices to same-sex borrowers, with Sun H. , *PNAS*, 116(19) (2019): 9293-9302. (invited to testify in front of the **Congress** and speak at the U.S. **HUD** and

- Federal Reserve; Featured by **ABC, Bloomberg, CNN, NBC, Washington Post, The Hill**, etc.)
22. Long-term stock returns following stock splits, the blind side, with Elnahas, A. and Ismail, G., *The Financial Review* , 54 (4) (2019): 801-831.
 23. Intraday Market Momentum, with Han, Y., Li, S., and Zhou, G. , *Journal of Financial Economics*, 129 (2018): 394-414.
 24. The Impact of Exogenous Corporate Governance Changes on Innovation and Market Value, with Zagorchev, A., *Quarterly Journal of Finance*, 8(01) (2018): 1840001.
 25. The monitoring of short selling: Evidence from China, with Deng, X.. *Research in International Business and Finance*. 43, (2018): 68-78
 26. Does local religiosity affect organizational risk-taking? Evidence from the hedge fund industry. with Wang, Y. and Zhao, J., *Journal of Corporate Finance* (Lead Article). 47 (2017): 1-22 (MFA, WFC, EFA Outstanding Paper Award)
 27. Corporate governance and performance of financial institutions, with Zagorchev, A., *Journal of Economics and Business*, 82 (2015): 17-41
 28. Firms' earnings smoothing, corporate social responsibilities, and valuation, with Zhang, J., *Journal of Corporate Finance*, 32 (2015): 108-127
 29. Corporate patents, R&D success, and tax avoidance, with Yang, L., and Zhang, J., *Review of Quantitative Finance and Accounting*, 7 (2015): 1-35
 30. Determinants of interfirm rivalry or cooperation: Implications for management. *Academy of Strategic Management Journal*, with Jackson, W. T., et. al.. 13 (2014): 113-128
 31. Investor attention and abnormal performance of timberland investments in the United States, with Mei, B., *Forest Policy and Economics*, 28 (2013): 60–65.
 32. Security price responses to unexpected earnings: a nonparametric investigation, with Wang, L., *Statistical Methods and Applications*, 20 (2011): 241–258.
 33. Intelligent transportation systems: an impact analysis for Michigan, with Farooq, U., Siddiqui, M., and Hardy, J.. *Journal of Advanced Transportation*, 46 (2012): 12–25.
 34. Economic impact/forecast model of intelligent transportation systems in Michigan: an input output analysis, with Farooq, U., Hardy, J., and Siddiqui, M. . *Journal of Intelligent Transportation System*, 12 (2008): 86–95.

OTHER PUBLICATIONS

1. CMEIAS v3.0 UPGRADE: Advanced image analysis software to strengthen microscopy-based approaches for understanding microbial ecology. *The 11th International Symposium in Microbial Ecology, Vienna, Austria*, with Dazzo, F., et al. (2006).
2. CMEIAS v3.0: Advanced image analysis software to strengthen microscopy-based approaches for understanding microbial ecology. *The 2006 Kellogg Biological Station Long-term Ecological Research Symposium and Poster Forum*, with Dazzo, F., et al. (2006).
3. Integrating heterogeneous systems in logistics industry with web services technology. *The 10th Industrial Engineering and Engineering Management*, with Yuan, X. (2003).

SELECTED WORKING PAPERS

1. The Rainbow of Credits: Evidence from Municipal borrowing, with Steve Liu and Ying Wang, (**AEA 2025** paper), target ***Journal of Finance*** ;
2. Balancing Short-term and Long-term Goals: How CIO Compensation Affects Enterprise System Investments, with Cao, C., Jiang, Z., and Qu, X., Resubmission invited at ***Information Systems Research*** (Dallas24, FT50);
3. Are Female CEOs Better Innovators? with Deng, X. and Han, J. (**AEA 2020**). under Review at ***Journal of Financial Economics***;
4. Seeing is Believing: Annual Report "Graphicity" and Stock Returns Predictability, with Deng, X., Hu, B., and Zhou, G. Under Review at ***Management Science***;
5. The Role of Retail Investors in the "Numbers Game": Retail Investor Attention and Earnings Management, with Chen, R. and Olsen, B. (Under Review at ***Management Science***);
6. Stock Anomalies Inside Industries, with Han, Y., Zhu, Y., and Zhou, G. (2023+);
7. Classified Boards, Debt Contracting, and Firm Value, with Nguyen, N. and Zagorchev, A., Under Review ;
8. Information asymmetry, management entrenchment, and capital structure: evidence from the Sarbanes-Oxley Act of 2002, (FMA)
9. The relation between management earnings forecast and sustainability disclosure: complementary or substitutive, with Rezaee, Z. and Tuo, L.,
10. Inequality and the COVID-19 Pandemics, with L. Wang et. al..
11. Online Information Acquisition and Investor Trading, with Li, O., and Yeung, E.. ***SSRN Top 10 download list***.
12. Multi-market information flows: market efficiency and return predictability, with Deng, X. and Kemme, D. (2023+). Under Review

13. Short selling, post-earnings-announcement drift, earnings surprises, and consecutive earnings surprises, with Okegualé, K. and Sun, M. (FMA , AAA)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- **Associate Professor**, School of Business, George Mason University

<i>FNAN303 Financial Management</i>	SPRING 2023
<i>FNAN311 Principles of Investment</i>	FALL 2021
<i>FNAN430 Empirical Methods in Finance</i>	FALL 2021
<i>FNAN311DL Principles of Investment</i>	SPRING 2023
<i>GBUS643 Managerial Finance</i>	SPRING 2023
<i>MSF702 Corp Fin Policy & Valuation</i>	SPRING 2022
<i>MBA643 Managerial Finance</i>	SPRING 2024
<i>MBA703 Financial Markets</i>	SPRING 2024

- **Assistant Professor**, Dept. of Finance, Iowa State University

<i>FIN320 Investments</i>	FALL 2014, 2015, 2017, 2018, 2020; SPRING 2017, 2019, 2021
<i>FIN425 Security Analysis and Portfolio Management</i>	FALL 2014, 2015, 2016, 2017; SPRING 2015, 2016, 2017, 2018

- **Assistant Professor**, Dept. of Finance, Insurance & Real Estate, University of Memphis

<i>FIR3710 Investments</i>	SPRING 2013, 2014; FALL 2012, 2013
<i>FIR6721 FIR4721 Financial Derivative Markets</i>	SPRING 2014

- **Instructor**, Dept. of Banking & Finance, University of Georgia

<i>FINA3000 Financial Management</i>	SUMMER 2008, 2009
<i>FINA4920 Computers in Finance</i>	SPRING 2009, 2012; FALL 2008

- **Instructor**, Dept. of Mathematics, Michigan State University

<i>MTH 124 Survey of Calculus I</i>	SPRING 2006; FALL 2005
<i>MTH1825 Intermediate Algebra (online)</i>	SUMMER 2005
<i>MTH 133 Calculus II</i>	SPRING 2005
<i>MTH 116 College Algebra and Trigonometry</i>	FALL 2004

- **Instructor and Translator**, Center for International Trade and Security, U. Georgia
Delivered lectures to large international firms' executives.

<i>Financial Management instructor, and other sessions' translator</i>	2009–2011
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OTHER WORKING EXPERIENCE

- **Programmer/Analyst**, Michigan Millers Mutual Insurance, Lansing, MI 2006–2007
- **Project Lead/E-Commerce Engineer**, OOCL , Shanghai & SanJose, CA 2000–2004

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIP

- American Finance Association (AFA)
- American Mathematical Society (AMS)
- European Finance Association(EFA)
- Financial Management Association (FMA)
- American Accounting Association (AAA)
- Northern Finance Association (NFA)
- Midwestern Finance Association (MFA)

ADMINISTRATIVE & GOVERNANCE SERVICE

- Chair, Graduate Policy Committee
- Member, Council on Inclusive Culture and Excellence
- Research Seminar Coordinator

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

- **Journal Editing Service**
Editor Assistant, Journal of Corporate Finance 2008–2012
- **Referee Service :**
NSF CAREER Award Grant, American Economic Review: Insight, Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis, Management Science, Review of Finance, Research Policy, Journal of Corporate Finance, Financial Management, Journal of Banking and Finance, Journal of Operations Management, Journal of Business Research, The Financial Review, The European Journal of Finance, Journal of Business Ethics, Journal of Financial Research, International Review of Economics and Finance, Journal of Applied Statistics,
- **Book review**
“*Financial Management*” by S. Titman, A. Keown and J. Martin.
- **Conference Committee, Chair, Discussant and Referee Service**
External Tenure cases reviewer (5) 2025(2),2024(2), 2023

Australian National University(ANU) Ph.D. student External Examiner	2019
Financial Management Association Conference	2020 – 2012
Midwestern Financial Association	2017, 2016, 2015
Southern Financial Association	2011, 2010
Eastern Financial Association	2012

STUDENTS SUPERVISION

- **Committee Member for Ph.D and M.S. students**

Ph.D Student Committee member: Md Noman Hossain, University of Texas, Rio Grande Valley (2020); MS(Iowa State University) Yue Zhang (2018); MS(University of Memphis), Jordan Lee Stroupe (2014), Eric Williams (2013), Richard Bou (2013), James Moye (2013, Chair), W. R. Toler (2013), William Arnold (2012).

- **Collaboration with former Ph.D. students**

Wesley Xiaohu Deng (UNSW), Mohamed Mekhaimer (Clarkson U.), Ahmed Elnahas (The University of Texas Rio Grande Valley), Ghada Ismail (Eastern Kentucky U.), Minxing Sun (Clemson University), Vivek Sharma (University of Memphis), Wei Sun (University of Memphis).

CONFERENCE/SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS/TALKS

- **2026**

INDAM (Pune, India, scheduled), University of Louisville (scheduled)

- **2025**

Financial Management Association Annual Conference(1 presentation, 2 discussions, 2 chair), Tokyo Metropolitan University, Waseda University, Keio University, George Mason University, Symbiosis International University, American Economic Association Annual Meeting, Eastern Economic Association

- **2024**

George Mason University, European Finance Association Annual Meeting (EFA), Financial Management Association Annual Meeting, American Economic Association Annual Meeting, APPAM Fall Research Conference, Southern Economic Association, SIBM-Pune

- **2023**

Macquarie University, Temple University*, The Accounting and Finance Association of Australia and New Zealand(AFA-ANZ)*, Southern Finance Association Annual Meeting, Academy of Finance meeting, George Mason University

- **2022**

American Finance Association Conference, SFS Cavalcade, China International Conference in Finance (CICF), Financial Management Association Annual Meeting (FMA), George Mason University, 2022 FMA Asia Pacific Conference, Southwestern Finance Association Annual Meeting, Xi'an Jiaotong University, 120 Initiative to Reduce Gun Violence consortium

- **2021**

Financial Management Association Annual Meeting, Shanghai International Finance Research Centre, Cheung Kong Graduate School of Business, Chinese University of Hong Kong (Shenzhen), Dongbei University of Finance and Economics, Jinan University, Macquarie University, Syracuse University, University of Bath, University of Liverpool, University of Melbourne, LGBTQ+ Real Estate Alliance, International FinTech Conference, and Pacific Basin Finance, Economics, Accounting and Management Conference

- **2020**

Washington University in St. Louis, George Mason University, University of Texas Rio Grande Valley*, American Economic Association Annual Meeting, Mid-Atlantic Research Conference in Finance(canceled), Financial Management Association Annual Meeting, Southern Finance Association

- **2019**

European Finance Association Annual Meeting, China International Conference in Finance, U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC), U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD), U.S. Congress*, University of Kansas, Financial Management Association Annual Meeting, Financial Management Association Asia Pacific Meetings, Macquarie University, University of Tasmania, Florida International University, Midwestern Finance Association Meetings, Iowa State University, American Economics Association Conference (AEA, AFA, ASSA)

- **2018**

American Economics Association Conference (AEA, AFA, ASSA), U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD), Iowa State University, Wilfrid Laurier University, Financial Management Association Asia Pacific Meetings, Peking University, Tsinghua University, Fudan University, Renmin University, University of International Business and Economics, Central University of Finance and Economics, Macquarie University, University of Tasmania, Shanghai Lixin University, Financial Management Association Meetings

- **2017**

2017 Financial Research Network (FIRN) Meeting, 28th Annual Conference on Financial Economics & Accounting, Financial Management Association Meetings (3

papers, 1 discussion), The China International Conference in Finance, Nankai University, Shandong University, Central University of Finance and Economics, Shandong University of Finance and Economics, Midwestern Finance Association Meetings

- **2016**

Financial Management Association Meetings (2 papers, 1 discussion), American Accounting Association Conference*, University of Iowa, Iowa State University, Nankai University, Shandong University, Xiamen University, Wuhan University, Southwestern University of Finance and Economics, Financial Accounting and Reporting Section (FARS) Midyear Meeting, Midwestern Finance Association Meetings (2 papers), Eastern Finance Association Meetings*, World Finance Consortium*

- **2015**

American Mathematical Society (AMS) Central Spring Sectional Meeting*, Financial Management Association Meetings (2 papers), Midwestern Finance Association Meetings (2 papers), Mid-Atlantic Research Conference in Finance (MARC)*, American Accounting Association Conference, Northern Finance Association Conference (NFA), ITAM Finance Conference*, Southwestern Finance Association Meetings*

- **2014**

Financial Management Association Meetings (2 papers), American Accounting Association Conference (3 papers), Australasian Finance & Banking Conference, World Finance Consortium, Northern Financial Association Conference, The China International Conference in Finance, International Symposium on Financial Engineering and Risk Management*, Tsinghua University Workshop*, Iowa State University

- **2013**

Financial Management Association Meetings, University of Mississippi,

- **2012**

Financial Management Association Meetings, Financial Accounting and Reporting Section (FARS) Midyear Meeting, Research Affiliates, University of Memphis, University of Georgia,

- **2011**

Financial Management Association Meetings, Conference on Financial Economics and Accounting, Bloomington University of Georgia (2), Eastern Finance Association Annual Meetings.

- **2010**

Southern Finance Association Annual Meetings, Asheville, University of Georgia, Athens